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A Fine Balance

This home by Elicyon in Umm Al Sheif creates a sense of intimacy at every turn

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Spanning an impressive 1,564 square metres (16,835 square feet), maintaining a sense of intimacy was one of the foremost challenges for Charu Gandhi, founder of the London-based interior design studio Elicyon. Working within the villa's existing contemporary architecture, Gandhi and her team softened the expansive volumes for an Emirati family, introducing layers of warmth and creating intimate pockets within the open-plan layout – without compromising the home's inherent spaciousness and grandeur. The resulting aesthetic is a timeless contemporary palette with subtle classical inflections.

This multi-generational family villa spans four levels, comprising four principal bedrooms, four guest bedrooms, and numerous family gathering spaces designed for both formal and informal occasions. The villa also features a cinema, treatment room, gym and a swimming pool. Significant reconfigurations on the second floor have been undertaken, including a conservatory style extension to the second floor to house all the gym equipment the client desired. Layering into some of the existing basebuild, Elicyon transformed the residence with bespoke joinery, luxurious tailored finishes and decorative elements. The new wooden flooring from esteemed Italian manufacturer Foglie D'Oro has infused the property with a welcoming warmth. The family were especially keen to work with British and local artisans, allowing the studio to create some beautifully crafted unique finishes, which are infused into the property.



The new stairway design features fluted details on the balustrade and walls, complemented by a bas relief motif that extends through all floors, seamlessly integrating with the property's existing footprint. A glass sculpture by Sans Souci flows through the staircase void, adding a captivating touch.

The ground floor's open-plan living spaces were elegantly partitioned with laminated Japanese washi paper panels crafted by Biden Designs, creating distinct zones for living and dining. A chandelier by Haberdashery adorns the double-height living area, featuring a cascade of porcelain flower buds that descend from the ceiling.

The home showcases a deliberate use of controlled repetition. Clear motifs such as chamfered edges, pearl-essent finishes and harmonious tonalities form a visual symphony that unites the various spaces. Starting with a warm ivory base in the formal majlis, Elicyon incorporated

Previous spread – The ground floor's open-plan living spaces were elegantly partitioned with laminated Japanese washi paper panels crafted by Biden Designs. A chandelier by Haberdashery adorns the double-height living area. **Right page** – In the formal majlis a warm ivory base is incorporated with subtle and calm colours of pistachio and celadon green, soft yellow and grey blue, which was then harmonised with golden accents and mother-of-pearl inlays





This page (from left) The master bedroom headboard is adorned with delicate hand-painted flowers on gold leaf panels by Rima & McRae; The en-suite bathrooms boast Ann Sacks mosaic floors and walls

colours that are subtle and calm – a blend of pistachio and celadon green, soft yellow and grey-blue, which was then harmonised with golden accents and mother-of-pearl inlays. Local craftsmanship has played a significant role in the project, with specialist plaster walls created by Alnubaidi Modern Decorative Systems in Dubai and a ceramic wall installation in the formal dining room by local artist Luxinova.

The bedrooms feature hand-embroidered wallpapers from Promental and de Gournay, while the en-suite bathrooms boast Ann Sacks mosaic floors and walls. The master bedroom headboard is adorned with delicate

hand-painted flowers on gold leaf panels by Rima & McRae. This floral motif is also beautifully incorporated into the rug and bespoke embroidery on the bedding, adding a beautiful touch of detail. The dressing room showcases a handcrafted porcelain sculpture from Nuzum Collective, and the wardrobe doors feature metal mesh laminated into glass by Belgium supplier LCD Textiles. The en-suite features Sakura flower mosaic flooring from Artistic Tile, surrounded by striking opal blue marble.

The basement family room features an especially elaborate joinery piece, with an inset mother-of-pearl TV unit crafted by a specialist

artisan in India. The design is masterfully created, with carefully curated contemporary and antique pieces through collaborations with galleries and artists.

From objets d'art selected at the Maison & Objet fair in Paris to unique sculptures from Vessel Gallery, these objects impart a distinctive depth and character to the space, elevating the interiors. In total, the property features no less than 150 bespoke pieces of upholstery and furniture created in-house by the design team. The result is a masterpiece of refined harmony in contemporary design – a home that blends international artistry with local craftsmanship.